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Sabotage

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Until you can dismantle them, he tells himself, always use the oppressors' tools against them.

Tim Maughan

The early 19th century in England has been described as "The Age of Machine Breaking," and the fact is that the history of the sabotage of machinery goes back a long way. Many contentious contemporary reinterpretations have written off those first acts of disobedience as a primitive reaction to progress. However, some researchers point out that phenomena such as the Luddites movement of 1811 to 1816 or the Swing Riots of 1830, more than just simple opposition to innovation, were forms of social protest against the use of machines that degraded working conditions in factories and made them more precarious, drove down wages and de-skilled and robbed craftspeople of their autonomy. And so it is that most historical episodes of resistance to the mechanisation brought in by the first wave of industrialisation show us that sabotage was essentially a reaction to the ways in which technology was used to centralise power and strip workers of agency.

More than two hundred years have passed, but some things don't seem to have changed much. We are currently living in a techno-feudalist economic order in which a handful of tech companies have almost absolute control over critical digital resources and generate revenue through our dependence on these infrastructures. It is what is known as

surveillance capitalism, in which these feudal lords (or "technolords") accumulate capital by extracting and monetising our personal data. Our attention, then, is their most valuable asset. All the time we spend looking at their screens is time that feeds a system that disconnects us from the real world. We no longer know the origin of the food we eat, the clothes we wear, the electricity we use... When was the last time we felt that interdependence with the Earth, its minerals, its seas and everything that the planet's ecological systems and biodiversity give us and do to sustain life? Furthermore, it is a system that not only disconnects us from the physical world around us, but is also destroying it through colonial extractive mining practices in the Global South, the burning of fossil fuels and the return of nuclear power to keep data centres – which are being imposed across the word at a dizzying pace – online.

In this new world order, two centuries after the first Luddite uprisings, the big tech companies have perfected the tools, but they continue to use technological machinery to exert control and discipline over us. To the point where they have made us normalise living in such a world, resign ourselves and somehow agree to be part of the machinery that sustains a system which is one step away from self-immolating and causing the mass extinction of our species. But *is this really fine*?

In 1971, William Powell published *The Anarchist Cookbook*, in which, between recipes for making tear gas in the garage and building detonators, he devoted an entire chapter to "Electronics, Sabotage & Surveillance", in which he explained, among other things, how to disrupt or tamper with telecommunications systems. Following his model, and adapting it to the 21st century, this article attempts to compile various methods of technological sabotage (for all tastes and levels of expertise), classified into two main categories: hard sabotage and soft sabotage. Hard sabotage is that which directly disrupts the functioning of a technical system and can be practised in two dimensions: the material, in which a disruption of the physical functioning of the infrastructure is proposed in the style of Andreas Malm, and the informational, in which the system continues to

exist, but with degraded operational capacity (for example cyber-attacks by hacktivist groups such as Anonymous or the electronic civil disobedience of RedHack against Erdoğan's government in Turkey and Telecomix during the Arab Spring. Soft sabotage, on the other hand, is that which aims mainly to reduce the system's efficiency from within – not by destroying the machine, but by making its operations so difficult, inefficient and costly that it ceases to be an effective tool of control. This would be what James C. Scott calls "everyday resistance," and it includes all those practices of lentitude, negligence, deliberate inefficiency and non-cooperation that generate some kind of systemic friction.

If we start with hard sabotage, we must consider several key infrastructures. Submarine fibreoptic cables, for example, carry more than 95% of the world's data traffic, making them the physical basis of the global network and, therefore, high-value targets for sabotage. Cables break with relative frequency, almost always due to apparently accidental causes (ship anchors, trawling nets, submarine landslides, etc.), but if we look a little closer, there are clear precedents for damage to similar infrastructure dating back to the First World War. In 1914, for example, the United Kingdom cut several submarine telegraph cables that connected Germany with the rest of the world, and in 2007 and 2008, two of the most important submarine cables in the Mediterranean and the Persian Gulf (the SEA-ME-WE 4 and the FLAG Europe-Asia) were sabotaged almost simultaneously, although the means of sabotage were never fully clarified. A second high-value infrastructure is data centres, which concentrate vast technological power in the processing, storage and control of the vast majority of the digital services we use. In recent wars we have seen countries' telecommunications facilities and data centres attacked as strategic infrastructure targets [1]. Recently, on 1 March 2026, Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) publicly claimed responsibility for drone attacks on several Amazon Web Services (AWS) data centres in the United Arab Emirates and Bahrain. This highlighted how in contemporary warfare, cloud infrastructure is an increasingly common military target,

and how the technological infrastructure underpinning the system becomes visible when it breaks down.

In terms of the informational dimension there is a much longer tradition, with proposals ranging from the tampering with or corruption of data to the introduction of deliberate viruses that trigger complete system shutdowns. There are disruptive attacks such as DDoS (Distributed Denial of Service), for example, which bring down websites, applications or services by overwhelming the infrastructure. Operation Payback in 2010, in which Anonymous organised coordinated DDoS attacks against companies such as PayPal, Visa and Mastercard that had blocked donations to WikiLeaks, is a paradigmatic example. In the last decade, we have also seen malware being used with the aim of actively damaging computer systems, as was the case with the cyberattack on the Colonial Pipeline in May 2021, which affected the US fossil fuel market for months and showed that all it took to sabotage fossil capital infrastructure and pipelines was a few computers. More directly linked to social movements and activism, sabotage has also been used against cloud-connected video surveillance systems. An example is the sabotage of the video surveillance systems start-up Verkada carried out by the group APT-69420, which in 2021 exposed recordings from over one hundred fifty cameras to denounce the culture of mass surveillance in schools, hospitals, prisons and factories in the US. In recent months we have also seen several coordinated digital strikes and boycotts of platforms such as Amazon, Apple, Netflix, Spotify, OpenAI, Google and Meta. An example is the famous economic resistance campaign Resist and Unsubscribe promoted by Scott Gallaway in the face of the police brutality perpetrated by ICE, with the aim of boycotting more than $250 million of market capitalisation through mass subscription cancellations. Other forms of sabotage which are more symbolic but at the same time highly effective include poisoning AI training data through imperceptible modifications to digital images using tools such as Nightshade or Glaze which cause models to misinterpret them, or subtly distorting personal photographs to prevent identification by facial

recognition systems using software like Fawkes.

In addition to all these, let us not forget soft sabotage, which is within almost everyone's grasp and requires nothing more than a purposeful commitment not to give the system what it so desperately craves – the optimisation of our time. It involves certain inconveniences and a sense of disagreement with the frenetic pace and hyper-productivity of our times, but in return it offers peace, generous doses of autonomy and a feeling of freedom that is hard to describe. These are small, modest actions, but if carried out en masse they can be very powerful. The Simple Sabotage Field Manual, published in 1944 by the Office of Strategic Services (OSS), demonstrates this: it set out a series of specific protocols for office staff aimed at subverting authoritarian systems through incompetence and the manipulation of bureaucracy. The text includes measures as comical as replying to superiors with very long and incomprehensible explanations to sow confusion, and wasting time or storing and filing documents and tools in the wrong places to create disorder and chaos. Although its usefulness depends on where we work, it is a text worth consulting, and below we list some examples of soft sabotage that we can start applying in our day-to-day digital lives. When our mobile or computer asks us to optimise the operating system, why do we obey by installing the latest version as if there were no other option? Here, the means of sabotage is very simple – stick with the old version that works and will continue to do so for a long time to come. And in this case, maximising the lifespan of our tech devices is also a way to fight against planned obsolescence. Another tactic is simply to not give away our data by practising what is known as "data starvation" – if we don't rate content, don't accept cookies, don't click on recommendations, don't react to posts and disable ads, we are refusing to work for free and to give away the data labour that allows big tech to optimise their algorithmic recommendation systems. Furthermore, if we coordinate our efforts, we will be disrupting the user activity feedback loops that allow big tech to keep its competitive advantage, and we will also be contributing to the gradual but significant degradation of the

system's overall performance. If we wish to browse without leaving a trace (or less of one), we can use browsers like Firefox and Brave with alternative search engines such as DuckDuckGo and add a good combination of extensions to block ad-tracking. A good cocktail would be uBlock Origin, Privacy Badger, Cookie AutoDelete, Decentraleyes and TrackMeNot.

The final soft sabotage tactic in this brief manual involves making subversive or improper use of the tech companies' own tools, disrupting the optimisation rhythm for which they were designed and which largely sustains them. If you watch YouTube videos in 360p instead of 4K, disable autoplay and notifications, avoid streaming, browse in reading mode or follow content via RSS that prioritises chronological over algorithmic browsing, you will also be doing your bit towards technological sabotage of the system. Some very useful extensions in this area are low-web, News Feed Eradicator, Just Read and Unhook.

As you can see, there are means of sabotage available to everyone, and just as the Luddites smashed machines, we can start by refusing to feed them. Because, no matter how much we've been led to believe otherwise, the machines don't run by themselves – they depend on our attention and our time. And if we offer them resistance and friction, we can build a technology that serves life.

1. ^ *This is the case with the Russian invasion of Ukraine, which since 2022 has carried out operations against telecommunications infrastructure through cyber-attacks such as the "Kyivstar hack" in December 2023, and missile strikes on mobile phone masts and fibreoptic lines to cut off communications. Furthermore, the mass use of FPV drones to prevent electronic sabotage is having a significant environmental impact, as it has turned many fields and urban areas into large cable dumps.*